Even before the kick-off, things felt completely different. The stakes were so much higher: it wasn't just me who was really hyped up. We were just starting to take England games to different club grounds around the country after Wembley had closed down. Everybody knew the atmosphere would be great at Anfield, although nobody was quite sure what kind of reception the United players would get at Liverpool's home ground. We shouldn't have worried. Whether they were Liverpool supporters or fans from around the country, the sound of the crowd chanting my name before kick-off made the hairs stand up on the back of my neck. It was great for me personally, but, much more important, it gave you the feeling that everybody had rallied round England and rallied round Sven.

Early on, we were flying. We created lots of scoring chances. There was a great energy in the team. Passes went where they were supposed to go. It felt really good. And then Finland scored. The ball bounced past Dave Seaman off Gary Neville's knee, a lucky goal, but it meant we were 1–0 down. *Oh, no. Not again.*

Then Michael Owen got an equalizer just before half-time from Gary's cross, which meant we went into the dressing room feeling pretty upbeat about our chances. Confident even, although I know our supporters probably weren't. We came back out for the second half and I got what turned out to be the winner. The ball came across from the left to the back of the penalty area and my first touch took it down at an angle that made shooting the easy option. I swung at it, the shot took a deflection off a defender and the ball flew into the far corner: my first goal for England from open play. I spun round and the first person I saw was Teddy Sheringham, warming up on the touchline. I launched myself, and jumped on his back celebrating. Dave Seaman made a great save towards the end. He always seemed to do that in the really big games. But my goal was the winner, which made it even sweeter.

We had to beat Finland just to give us a chance. Germany in Munich was five months away and we knew we had to keep ourselves in the hunt, at least, until then. We had qualifiers in Greece and Albania and exhibitions, too, ahead of us. Now was the time to find out about ourselves as a team. Sven trusted the young players he'd inherited from Peter Taylor—a whole generation, really, mid-twenties and under—and gave us the time and the games to build up our confidence. Over those early months there was a bit of a United feel about how things developed. There still is. And I don't just mean because of myself and Gary, Phil, Butty and Scholesy.